

Agent Passport Standards Series
APS 1001 (2026), revision 3
Series 1000: Payment Rails
Category: Proposed Industry Standard

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8 September 2026

APS 1001

Agent Passport Standard: Delegated Authority of AI Agents on Payment Rails

Status of this Memo

APS 1001 specifies the procedure by which an AI agent proves, before a payment executes, that it acts within a current, human-granted authority, and by which the bank that executes the payment records evidence of what it verified. It is a proposal for an industry standard, demonstrated on synthetic data. It does not describe a current legal requirement, and no regulator has approved it. Distribution is unlimited.

Revision 3 replaces the authority approval of revision 2 with a bank-operated model: an industry register records AI products, each bank decides which registered products its customers may delegate to, and the regulator receives evidence through normal supervisory processes without operating or approving anything.

Abstract

An AI agent that can be identified can still act beyond what its principal allowed. This document separates identity from authority. An Agent Passport is an envelope of three signed claims, each made by the only party entitled to make it: the bank, which admitted the AI product to its list; the customer, which deployed an agent on that product; and the same customer, which signed the mandate the agent must stay within. Behind them stands a register on which the product's provider filed its identity, an accountable principal, insurance and Independent Assurance Evidence. The bank verifies the envelope and the signed instruction with an ordered, deny-by-default procedure and answers ALLOW, ESCALATE or DENY with a rule citation and a signed receipt. Authority may be delegated but never expanded. Revocation is a list lookup. Every decision is replayable, and every passport can be exported as one self-verifying evidence bundle.

1. Introduction

Firms delegate invoice payment to AI agents. A bank receiving an instruction cannot determine which agent sent it, whether it was permitted to, or who answers for it. Since 2024, UK banks bear the loss when a misdirected payment is authorised. HM Treasury's 2026 consultation on modernising payment services regulation asks how authentication, consent and liability provisions should adapt to agentic payments. This standard gives the bank one verification call that answers those three questions before money moves, and gives a supervisor complete evidence afterwards without requiring it to inspect agents, products or transactions in advance.

The key words MUST, MUST NOT, SHOULD and MAY are to be interpreted as described in RFC 2119.

2. Terminology

Register	An industry-operated record of AI products. It records identity and accountability. It does not certify that AI agents are good; it guarantees that someone is accountable when they are bad.
Provider	The company that files an AI product on the register.
AI product	A named, version-pinned AI system filed by a provider.
Independent Assurance Evidence	A benchmark or audit report from a party other than the provider that the product meets the minimum assurance requirements for a stated use case. It is attached at filing and assessed by each relying bank, never by the register.
Bank	The relying party that executes payment instructions. It admits products to its list and verifies every instruction.
Customer	The legal person whose funds an AI agent moves.
AI agent	The customer's deployment of an admitted product: a private key, a configuration, a mandate.
Supervisor	A regulator that receives evidence through supervisory or incident processes. It operates no part of the infrastructure.
Passport	The envelope defined in Section 4. A passport that satisfies Sections 3 to 7 is APS 1001-conformant.

3. Registration and Admission

3.1 A provider MUST file an AI product on the register before any bank admits it. A filing MUST name the legal entity, an accountable principal with a signed declaration that the filing is accurate, insurance in force at or above the

minimum cover, the product and its pinned model version, the location of its documentation, and Independent Assurance Evidence naming the use case it covers. A filing MUST NOT name a customer or contain any mandate content.

3.2 The register MUST run completeness checks and record each result next to the entry:

- F.1 provider matches the companies register
- F.2 accountable principal named, with a signed declaration
- F.3 insurance evidenced, cover at or above the minimum, in force
- F.4 product documented with a pinned model version
- F.5 Independent Assurance Evidence attached and covering the registered use case
- F.6 product not already on the register

The register MUST sign a receipt for the filing. The register MUST NOT review, approve or rank filings.

3.3 A bank MUST decide for itself whether its customers may delegate payments to a registered product. The decision is the bank's; it MAY use any assessment it chooses, including its own evaluation of the Independent Assurance Evidence against the question "does this product meet the minimum assurance requirements for this use case". Automated review MAY recommend; a named officer MUST decide.

3.4 An admission MUST state the ceilings that every mandate on the product at that bank must satisfy (maximum per-payment limit, maximum rolling limit per payee account, maximum validity, permitted actions) and a hold condition (an amount above which the bank holds the instruction for a named person at the customer).

3.5 An admission MAY be suspended or withdrawn by the bank. Either act MUST cascade to every passport issued on the product at that bank.

4. The Passport

A passport MUST consist of three signed tokens (JWT, RFC 7519; EdDSA, RFC 8037) and an identifier:

admission	signed by the BANK: the admitted product (registration reference, name, identifier, version, hash of the register's receipt), ceilings, hold condition, validity, list pointer, and the hash of the agent_identity it
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The result MUST cite the rule that decided it and MUST be accompanied by a receipt signed by the bank. Limits live in the mandate; running totals live at the bank.

7. Delegation

Where an AI agent delegates to another, the delegation MUST be signed by the delegating key, and for scopes S_0 (mandate), $S_1 \dots S_n$:

S_n is a subset of $\dots S_1$ is a subset of S_0 , and the action is an element of S_n .

Delegation MAY narrow authority. It MUST NOT expand it.

8. Evidence

- 8.1 Every filing, admission, signature, lifecycle change, verification and incident MUST be recorded in an append-only, hash-chained log. Every verification MUST be reproducible from its recorded inputs.
- 8.2 Every refusal MUST be recorded with the instruction, the rule, the reason and, where a document produced the instruction, the extraction that produced it. A repeated refusal of the same rule SHOULD raise an alert at the bank.
- 8.3 For any passport the bank MUST be able to produce one evidence bundle: the register filing and receipt, the admission, the agent identity, the mandate, every verification with its inputs and receipt, the refusals, and the chain segment, verifiable with the published public keys. A supervisor MAY request such a bundle through normal supervisory or incident processes. The export MUST itself be recorded.

9. Lifecycle

File	A provider files an AI product (Section 3.1).
Admit	A bank runs its own assessment and admits the product with ceilings and a hold condition (Sections 3.3, 3.4).
Issue	A customer registers an AI agent and signs a contained mandate; the passport is issued at signing (Section 5).
Act	The bank verifies each instruction (Section 6).
Detect	Every refusal is recorded; patterns raise alerts.
Revoke	The bank sets the list status of a passport or of a product. The next instruction fails at R.2 on every rail that mirrors the mandate.
Evidence	Any passport can be exported as one bundle

(Section 8.3).

10. Governance

APS 1001 is written for adoption by an industry body on the precedent of the Open Banking Implementation Entity: the body maintains the standard and the register, banks adopt it through commercial schemes because they carry the fraud loss and the customer relationship, and regulators set guardrails and receive evidence without building, operating or approving the technology. Nothing in this standard requires or implies regulatory approval of any AI product.

11. Security Considerations

A copied passport is useless without the agent's private key (R.4). A forged or altered claim fails its signature (R.1, R.3, R.5). A manipulated agent that requests payment to an account the customer never listed fails R.6 regardless of how genuine the invoice appeared. A mandate cannot exceed the product's ceilings at that bank (Section 5.2). Compromise of the bank's key, and attestation of the running software, are out of scope.

12. What APS 1001 Does Not Specify

Settlement. Know-your-customer, sanctions or funds checks. Whether a payment is wise. Whether an AI product is good: the register records accountability and the bank makes its own assessment. Liability of the provider for an agent's conduct beyond the accuracy of its filing and the insurance it declared. Any judgement by a model: models read and draft; rules decide; humans sign.

13. References

APS 1002 (delegation chains, reserved), APS 2001 (tax rails, reserved), RFC 2119, RFC 7519 (JWT), RFC 7800 (cnf), RFC 8037 (EdDSA), RFC 9396 (Rich Authorization Requests), W3C Verifiable Credentials (JWT profile), NIST NCCoE 2026 (agent identity and authorization), FATF 2025 (AI and AML/CFT), HM Treasury (2026) Modernising Payment Services Regulation, section 3.2 and question 15; the Open Banking chapter of the same consultation.

Authors' Addresses

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Reference implementation: <https://cdir.legislabs.uk>
Source: <https://github.com/LegisLabs/agent-passport>